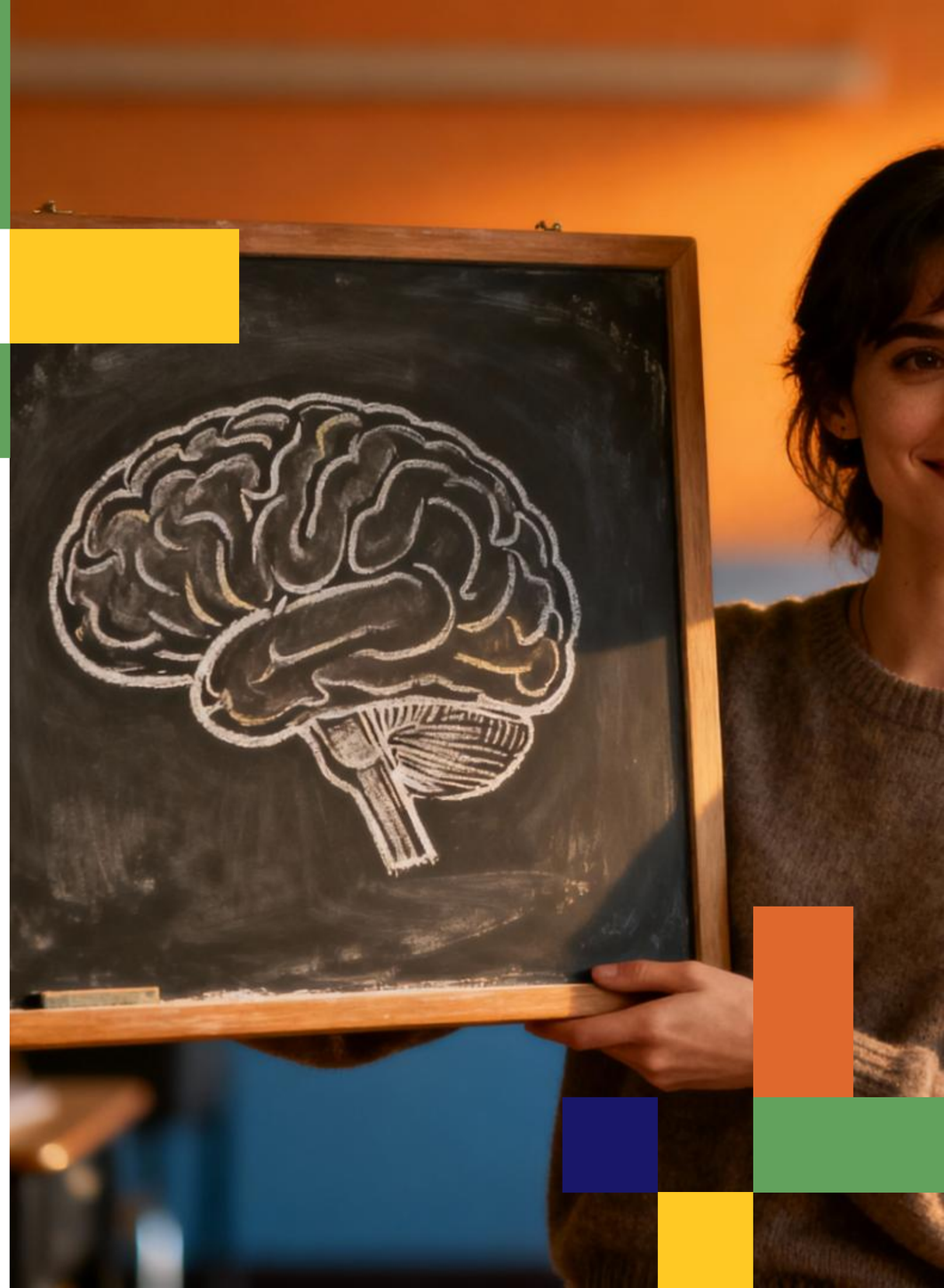
Topic 1: Foundation of Sport Psychology

This topic introduces the definition, scope, and nature of sport psychology, traces its historical development, and explains its core objectives. Learners explore how the field evolved, its key functions in enhancing performance and well-being, and how sport psychology operates within diverse sporting contexts to support athletes and teams.



Course Instructor: Chong Siew Kian

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this topic, students will be able to:

1. Explain the definition, scope, and nature of sport psychology (CLO1)

– Understand what sport psychology is and how it fits within psychology and sport science.
– Recognize its role in enhancing performance and well-being.

2. Describe the historical development of sport psychology as a discipline (CLO1)

– Identify key pioneers, milestones, and research contributions.
– Trace how the field evolved into modern applied practice.

3. Analyse the objectives and functions of sport psychology in different sporting contexts (CLO2)

– Understand how sport psychology supports athletes in mental skills, emotional regulation, and resilience.
– Connect these objectives with real-world applications in elite, recreational, and youth sports.

What is Sport Psychology?

- Sports psychology is the **scientific study of psychological factors** that **influence athletic performance** and how participation in sports and exercise can affect the psychological and physical well-being of athletes.

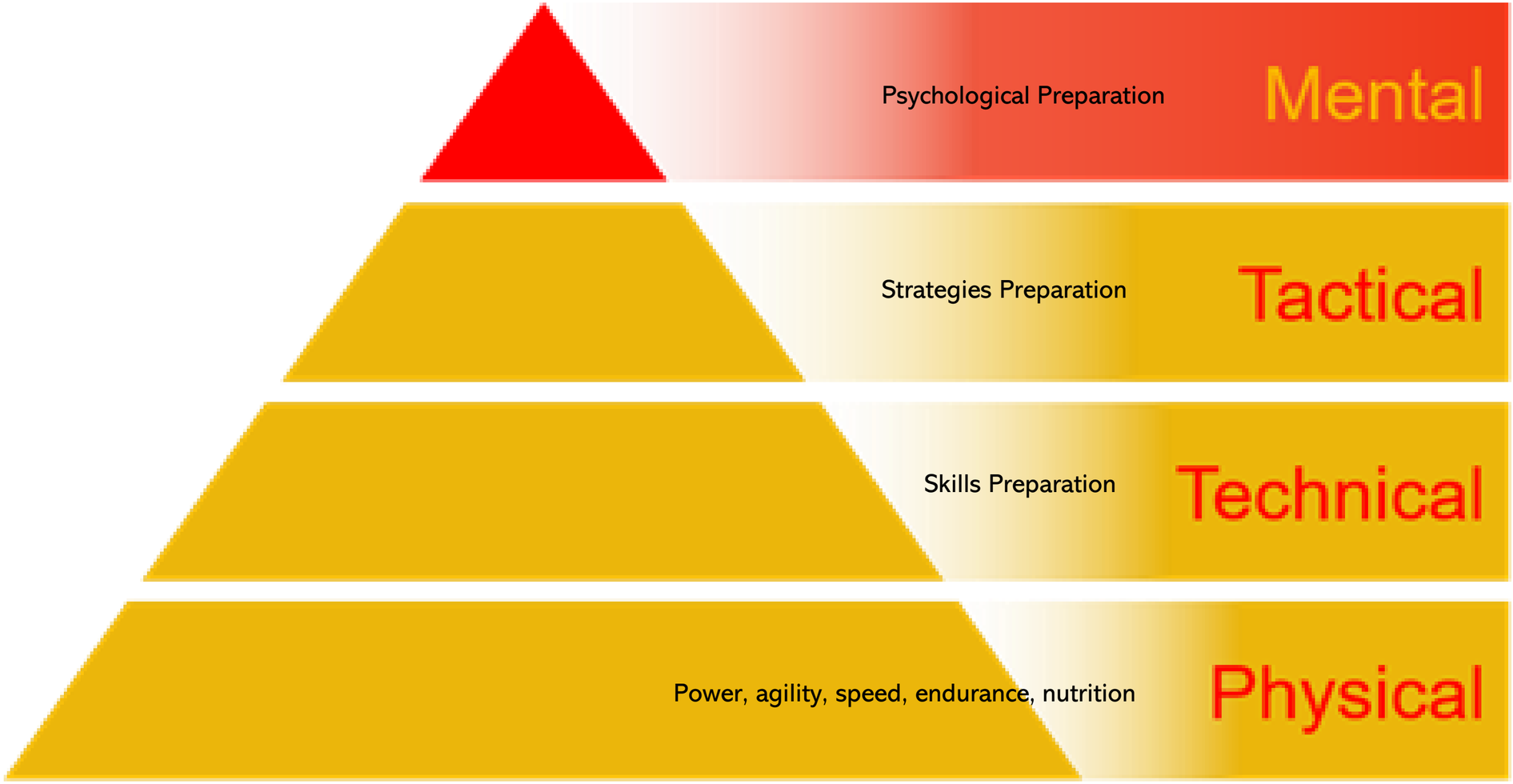
- It focuses on the psychological variables that influence physical activity and performance. Things like **anxiety, focus, motivation, visualization, stress and resilience** can all affect how well people do during exercise, physical activity, or athletic competition.

- Sports psychology is not only for **professional athletes**, but for **non-professional athletes** cope with the pressures of competition, enhance athletic performance, and achieve their goals.

- The tactics they use to **help elite performers excel** can also be utilized in recreational settings to help people enjoy sports, handle anxiety, and build motivation. **Techniques** like progressive muscle relaxation, hypnosis, and CBT can improve relaxation and concentration.

- Sport psychology is **interdisciplinary field** combining psychology and sport science (related fields such as biomechanics, physiology, kinesiology) that focuses on behaviour, performance, and athlete well-being.

Pyramid of Sport Performance



Scope of Sport Psychology

Three practical domains that shape performance, health, and team success

01 Performance enhancement

- Motivation strategies to boost drive
- Confidence building and self-efficacy
- Focus and visualization techniques
- Arousal regulation to optimize output

02 Athlete well-being

- Preventing burnout through recovery planning
- Stress management strategies
- Maintaining emotional health and resilience
- Support systems for mental wellness

03 Team dynamics

- Leadership development and role clarity
- Effective communication skills
- Building team cohesion and trust
- Group processes for consistent performance

1. Performance Enhancement in Sports Psychology

Train mental skills—motivation, focus, confidence, arousal—to deliver peak performance under pressure

Motivation — set meaningful goals and sustain drive

Focus — use concentration strategies and routines

Confidence — build self-belief through mastery and positive self-talk

Arousal regulation — breathe, relax, or psych-up to match task demands

Visualization — rehearse skills mentally to enhance execution

Stress management — identify triggers and apply coping strategies

Outcome — consistent peak performance under pressure

2. Promoting Athlete Well-being

Practical psychological strategies to prevent burnout, manage stress, and sustain emotional health

- Prevent **burnout** through scheduled rest and load monitoring
- Manage **stress** with relaxation techniques and CBT tools
- Support **emotional health** via mindfulness and counseling
- Balance **physical training** with mental recovery routines
- Foster **resilience** for sustainable athletic careers

3. Enhancing Team Dynamics

Leverage leadership, communication, and cohesion to boost motivation and performance

Leadership Training For Athletes And Coaches To Guide, Motivate, And Align Goals

Effective Communication: Clear Feedback, Active Listening, And Conflict Resolution

Group Cohesion Builds Trust, Balances Individual Goals With Team Success, And Raises Motivation

Sport Psychology Equips Teams With Skills For Leadership, Conflict Resolution, And Trust-building

Early Foundations of Sport Psychology

Key milestones from 1830 to 1891 that shaped the field

Late 1800s: Early psychology research in sport

1830

- Carl Friedrich Koch
- Linked **calisthenics**, **psychology**, and **dietetics**

1879

- Wilhelm Wundt
- Established psychology lab enabling early **sport psychology** experiments

1884

- Konrad Rieger
- Studied **muscular endurance** and **hypnosis**

1891

- Angelo Mosso
- Explored **mental fatigue** effects on physical performance

Origins of Sport Psychology

Key early figures and milestones shaping the field

01

1898

The term "**sport psychology**" was first used in 1900 by Pierre de Coubertin, who, along with Wundt, made significant contributions in the early 20th century.

02

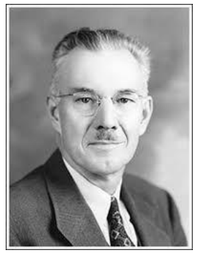
circa 1900

- **Norman Triplett (1898)**: First social facilitation study - demonstrated that bicyclists were more likely to cycle faster with a pacemaker or a competitor, which has been foundational in the literature of social psychology and social facilitation

03

1925

- **Coleman Griffith (1925)**: Father of Sport Psychology, he created the **Athletic Research Laboratory** at the University of Illinois.



Modern Sport Psychology: Evidence and Practice

Scientifically tested interventions and global professional support to boost performance, growth, and mental health

- **Evidence-based** interventions to enhance performance and well-being
- Shift toward **scientifically tested** methods and measurable outcomes
- International associations support global **professionalization**
- Applied psychologists focus on sustained **excellence, growth, and mental health**

Modern Sport Psychology

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Main Objectives of Sport Psychology

How mind and sport interact to boost performance and well-being

First main objective: to learn how psychological factors affect an individual's physical performance. First objective was traditional the emphasis.

Second main objective: to understand how participation in sport affects a person's psychological development, health and well-being. Then, the use of sport to enhance competence and promote human development throughout the lifespan.

Competitive, team, recreation

Competitiveness

Deal with healthy, motivated, and high achievement-oriented people striving for consistent excellence, performance up to their potential, and continuous self-development.

Team

Dealing with team-building issues and helping individual athletes find a balance between individual and team interests and values.

Recreation

Deal with non-professional athletes that form positive, proactive, and constructive nature of applied sport psychology

Applied Sport Psychology in Competition

Practical interventions to sustain peak performance under pressure

01

Maximize potential through customized mental skills training

02

Foster self-development: build resilience and long-term growth

03

Sustain high achievement via routine, recovery, and stress management

04

Enhance mental toughness & focus with simulation and rehearsal

05

Goal attainment: set structured, measurable short- and long-term targets

Role of Anxiety in Athletic Performance

How arousal levels help or hinder focus, tension, and decisions

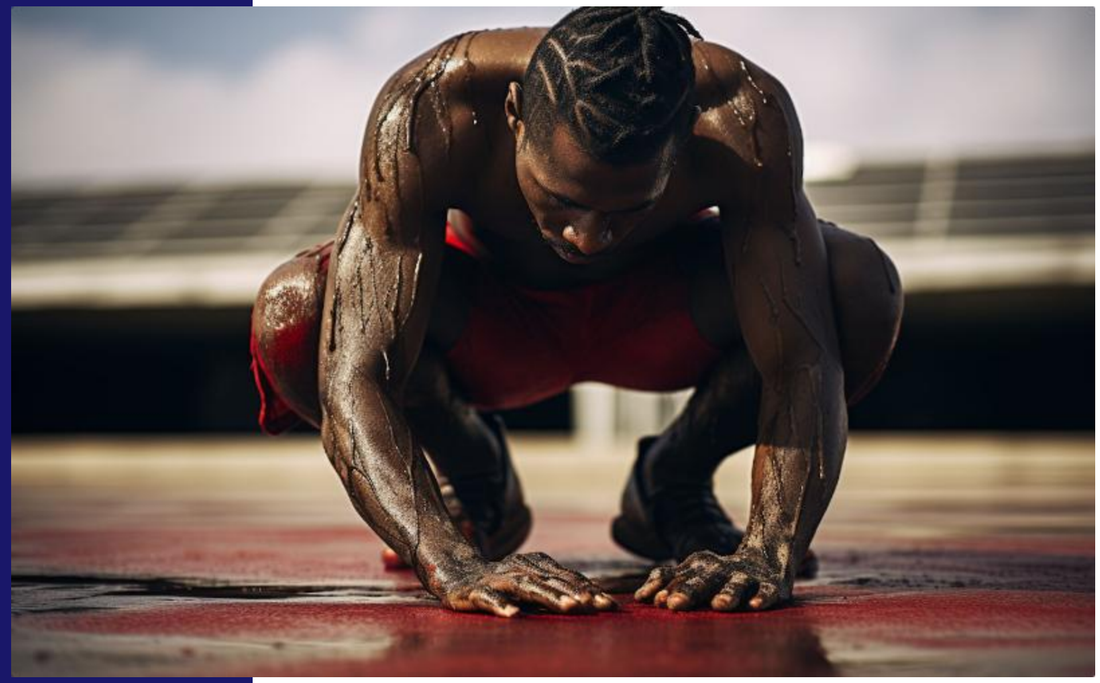
Anxiety affects concentration, muscle tension, and decision-making

Controlled arousal can enhance focus but must be managed

Excessive anxiety often **impairs performance**

Sport psychology teaches recognition and regulation of anxiety

Mental strategies promote **calmness** and optimal readiness



Motivation & Visualization: Fueling Peak Performance

How internal drive and mental rehearsal boost confidence, reduce anxiety, and sharpen readiness

Creates neural pathways similar to practice, enhancing **muscle memory**

Boosts **confidence**, reduces performance **anxiety**, and improves competitive readiness

Motivation drives commitment to train hard and persevere through setbacks

Visualization = mentally rehearsing skills and scenarios to prepare physically and emotionally

Stress and Resilience in Sport

How sport psychology helps athletes manage pressure and recover stronger

01 Stress reduces focus and energy; common in athletes

02 **Resilience** = adapt and recover; vital for sustained performance

03 Sport psychology trains coping strategies to build resilience

04 Key techniques: **mindfulness**, **positive self-talk**, **goal-setting**

05 Outcome: better pressure management and faster recovery from setbacks

Build Athlete Confidence for Peak Performance

Practical methods sport psychologists use to boost risk-taking, persistence, and belief

01 **Positive self-talk** to reframe challenges and reduce performance anxiety

02 **Mastery experiences**: progressive skill drills that build reliable success memories

03 **Social support** from coaches and teammates to sustain motivation and persistence

04 Use **reframing**: sport psychologists turn setbacks into learning opportunities

05 Outcome: stronger belief in ability → increased risk-taking, persistence, peak performance

Team Leadership & Communication: Drive Cohesion

Train captains and members to boost motivation, clarity, trust and joint performance

Motivation: leadership that sustains drive and aligns goals

Clarity & Trust: communication reduces confusion and builds reliability

Conflict Reduction: open dialogue prevents and resolves disputes

Supportive Environment: training equips members to foster cohesion

Improved Joint Performance: aligned teams deliver better outcomes

Developing Team Cohesion

How shared goals, trust, and sport psychology drive lasting team performance

Shared goals align individual motivation with the team mission

Mutual respect builds psychological safety and resilience

Effective collaboration improves communication and performance

Sport psychologists run trust-building exercises and goal-alignment interventions

Benefits: increased motivation, resilience, and long-term success

Sport Psychology’s Impact on Athletic Success

How mental skills, emotional health, and team dynamics boost performance and lifelong well-being

Mental skills training optimizes focus, visualization, and performance under pressure

Anxiety management & resilience reduce performance-limiting stress and improve consistency

Motivation cultivation sustains effort, goal pursuit, and long-term athletic development

Team building & collaboration enhance communication, trust, and collective success

Holistic well-being links mental health practices to lifelong physical and psychological benefits

Summary: Integrating these principles empowers sustained athletic success and well-being

Psychological Techniques That Boost Athletic Performance

Evidence-based methods to reduce anxiety, sharpen focus, and build confidence

Progressive muscle relaxation — reduces physical tension and anxiety; aids pre-competition calm

Hypnosis — enhances concentration and mental control; supports confidence and routine automation

Cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) — reframes negative thoughts, lowers performance anxiety, builds resilience

Visualization & imagery — practices peak performance mentally to increase focus and execution

Goal-setting & self-talk — structures motivation, reinforces confidence, improves concentration

Breathing techniques — quick anxiety reduction and refocusing between plays

Interdisciplinary Nature of Sport Psychology

Integrating mental and physical sciences to boost athlete performance and health

Sport Psychology

Studies psychological factors (anxiety, motivation, focus, visualization, resilience) that influence performance

Biomechanics

Analyzes movement mechanics to optimize technique and reduce injury risk

Physiology

Examines bodily systems (cardio, metabolic, recovery) that underpin performance and health

Kinesiology

Integrates movement science with training design and functional assessment

Sport Characteristics

Type of Sport	List of Sports
Target Sports	Archery, Shooting, Tenpin Bowling, Petanque, Lawn Bowl, Fencing
Racquet Sports	Badminton, Tennis, Table Tennis, Squash
Team Sports	Football, Basketball, Netball, Softball,
Martial Art	Taekwondo, Judo, Karate-do, Wushu, Boxing
Individual Sports	Athletics, Swimming, Diving, Gymnastic

Sports integrated with psychological focus

TYPE OF SPORT	PSYCHOLOGICAL FOCUS
Target Sports	Emotion, Focus, Momentum
Racquet Sports	Motivation, Confidence, Emotion, Focus, Coping, Arousal, Recovery, Stress Management, Decision-Making
Team Sports	Motivation, Confidence, Emotion, Focus, Coping, Recovery, Team cohesion
Martial Art	Motivation, Confidence, Arousal, Focus, Coping, Recovery, Fighting Spirit
Individual Sports	Motivation, Confidence, Emotion, Focus